

Currently, food and beverage inflation remains elevated, with an 8.66% increase in February. The recent uptick in global commodity prices also warrants close monitoring, with prices of Brent crude and industrial metals rising 4.4% and 5.5%, respectively, since the MPC's previous meeting in February. The RBI is also gauging the impact of previous rate actions and economic data before contemplating adjustments.

One section that could benefit from the stable rates is home loan borrowers, experts say. "A stable repo rate signals consistency in interest rates for borrowers, providing assurance regarding steady

positional to facilitate cash deposits in cash deposit machines (CDMs) through UPI and to enable UPI payments through Prepaid Payment Instruments (PPI) to enhance convenience and boost adoption of digital payments for small-value transactions.

Das said, "Deposit of cash through CDMs is primarily done with debit cards... It is now proposed to facilitate the deposit of cash in CDMs using UPI." He further announced the use of third-party UPI apps for payments through PPI wallets, stating, "At present, UPI payments from Prepaid Payment Instruments can be made only by using the web or

EYE ON INFLATION

- ▶ **RBI has kept the repo rate unchanged at 6.5%**
- ▶ **The central bank is treading cautiously since retail inflation has remained above its 4% target**

- ▶ **It is also watchful of the geopolitical tensions in the Middle East**
- ▶ **Analysts now expect interest rate cuts only towards the end of the year**

loan interest rates. Stable interest rates enhance affordability for potential homebuyers and foster consumer confidence," said Adhil Shetty, CEO of Bankbazaar.com.

In support of its stance, the RBI has highlighted the resilience of the global economy and the domestic economy witnessing strong momentum, anticipating real GDP growth of 7% for FY25. Deepak Sood, Senior Partner and Head of Fixed Income at asset management firm Alpha Alternatives, says, "The policy stance is firmly anchored towards ensuring medium-term price stability and supporting an inclusive and sustainable growth trajectory."

Another measure of note in the MPC meeting was the RBI's pro-

mobile app provided by the PPI issuer. It is now proposed to permit the use of third-party UPI apps for making UPI payments from PPI wallets."

Hailing this move, Vivek Iyer, Partner at consulting services firm Grant Thornton Bharat, says, "Enabling UPI for cash deposits is RBI's focus towards integrating UPI as a part of the entire financial services value chain. UPI access for PPI is a great step towards interoperability across the payment ecosystem. The RBI's mindset seems to be to broad-base UPI across the ecosystem in order to foster competition and help fuel further innovation." **BT**

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CRYPTO

A Rare Event

Bitcoin halving is coming near. Will this rare phenomenon make the crypto more expensive or is more volatility on the cards?

BY PRANAV DIXIT

▶ **IN THE MYSTERIOUS COSMOS** of cryptocurrencies, there exists a phenomenon called Bitcoin halving. Picture this: a cosmic dance of miners, investors, and enthusiasts, all eagerly awaiting the rare occurrence that has profound implications for the future of the world's most famous cryptocurrency.

Bitcoin operates on a schedule governed by code. Roughly every four years, or after every 210,000 blocks are mined, Bitcoin experi-

50
per cent

**IS BY HOW MUCH HALVING
REDUCES THE REWARD FOR
MINERS**

ences a halving event. This event reduces the reward miners receive for verifying transactions by 50%. As the supply of new Bitcoins dwindles, demand potentially surpasses supply, thus, propelling the price skywards. According to experts, the halving is expected between April 20 and 23 of this year.

According to Rajagopal Menon, Vice President at crypto exchange